



NOBODY LEAVES HUNGRY

A poem

Shane Thomas Strough

El Gringo Clandestino

"Not every act of love looks like arrival.

Sometimes it looks like iron.

Sometimes it looks like waiting."

— from the poem

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The Palmarcito Papers

At midnight, the ghost machine locks into place.
Forty-five thousand lines of logic.
An eight-layer engine breathing in the dark.
No gaps remain.
He leaves the credentials for tomorrow,
turns from the screen,
and lights the iron.

The fat cap renders in a fifteen-liter pot.
You do not trim it.
Fat is the vehicle for heat.
It carries the flame inward—
past surface,
past haste,
into the part that cannot be hurried
without being lost.

He drops the chiltepes in whole.
Crushing them is a choice you cannot unmake—
like walking away from the reactor,
like deciding in advance
that you will be the one
who knows where the exits are.

It takes twelve hours
on the lowest possible flame.
This is not the work of spectacle.
This is the work of calibration.
You have to know when to leave the lid on
and step back.
You have to know that interference
is not the same thing as care.

A thousand miles north,
she is filling a house with women—
Aunt Susan, Gramma Cindy,
the taking down of ugly photographs from the wall,
the old domestic archaeology
by which a life is cleared
for something better to enter.

He watches her face in the glass,
sixty meters from the Pacific,
screenlight between salt air and darkness,
and tells her to go sleep, zombie.
He tells her these three days of reggae and choripán,
of feeding strangers in the sand,
are only the first mouthful.

Because when you are calibrating
for the rest of your life,
you do not crowd the room.
You do not force the hinge.
You do not call urgency
by the holy name of love.
You give her the oxygen.
You call her penguino.
You let the distance do its stern
and necessary work.
You trust what is becoming
while it is still hidden
by heat and time.

Tomorrow the sun will hammer Playa El Palmarcito.
The musicians will wake up hungry.
The sea will go on breathing
its ancient indifference and gift.
He will stand over the stove
and add the last splash of vinegar—
not much,
just enough to wake the cumin,
to lift the dark weight of the pot,
to make the heavy labor
taste alive.

He is a man who builds architectures:
databases waiting for their keys,
pipelines parsing silence,
systems that must hold under pressure
when no one else knows
where the fault began.

But the deeper architecture is older than code.
It is this:
the patience to let the meat
give itself over to the gravy;
the hand steady enough
to keep the fire just under speech;
the discipline to choose slowness
when slowness is what saves the thing;
the knowledge that provision is not noise,
not dominance,
not standing in the center of the room
asking to be seen,
but building a structure sturdy enough
that others may enter it and breathe.

So whether it is a blank repository
waiting for its first true commit,
or a house full of women
pulling down the wrong inheritance from the walls,
or the woman he loves
standing a thousand miles north
inside the life that is making room for him—
he understands the mechanism.

Not every hunger
announces itself plainly.
Not every fire
should be fed all at once.
Not every act of love
looks like arrival.
Sometimes it looks like iron.
Sometimes it looks like waiting.
Sometimes it looks like knowing
exactly how long a thing must remain on the flame
before it becomes tender enough
to offer.

And this is his vow,
though he does not speak it like one:
that whether the need is code,
or shelter,
or heat,
or timing,
or a table wide enough
for strangers and musicians and the future alike,
he will make of his life
a mechanism of welcome.
A structure that holds.
A fire that answers hunger
without wasting itself.
A room with air in it.
A hand that does not tremble
when the long work begins.

Nobody leaves hungry.

— Shane Thomas Strough / El Gringo Clandestino / Palmarcito, El Salvador / 2026